

TOURNAMENTS OF VALUE:
SOCIABILITY AND HIERARCHY IN A YEMENI TOWN

**Excerpt for AN101—be sure to read only the pages specified (27–36, 49–41,
100–104, + preface included for your reference)**

with Magda for not visiting her when she was sick. She gave a dramatic account of her bout of malaria, saying she had expected a visit from her friends and neighbours, as visits are thought to lighten an illness. She exclaimed that even the foreigner, indicating me, had visited her on what she claimed was practically her deathbed, while the native Zabidis had neglected their well-known duties to the sick. (I had heard this sort of thing before: Zabidis referred to foreigners in the same tone as 'even a child!' or 'even a cretin!' – as people from whom nothing reasonable or considerate could rightly be expected.) I did not diminish the force of Najat's rhetoric by declaring the truth, which was that I had not even known she was sick, but had coincidentally dropped by to see her nephew's wife. In response to Najat's complaints, Magda asserted that she had sent her greetings with her mother, and Najat, still grumbling, hurried to take a place in the rapidly filling interior reception room, claiming that she did not want a further chill. Magda said to me under her breath, 'They [Najat and family] are so quarrelsome' and to Sayyida, she sniffed, 'Sick! She had malaria!' As common as the flu in North America, the seriousness of malaria as an illness was often underrated; women burning with fever often described themselves not as 'sick' [*marida*] but as merely 'a little tired' [*ta'abana shwayya*]. Little sympathy is accorded a suspected malingerer in a community where life-threatening illnesses are all too familiar.

The spacious courtyard, roughly twelve by eight metres, looked lovely in the dusk, with a couple of date palms set against the backdrop of the fine patterning of the outer façade of the house. This façade and the enclosing walls, three metres high, which surrounded the courtyard, sported a new coat of whitewash in honour of the festivities. Our hostess, Jamaliya, was often described as a housekeeping 'artist' [*fannana*], and all the women in her household helped her maintain this reputation. They had achieved the readiness for guests which yet eluded Bayt Mahmud Hazimi, as the reception area looked inviting, clean after the dust of the streets, and cool in the late afternoon as the heat of the day receded. To prevent dustiness, the ground had been swept and dampened down into a smooth, cool surface. The perimeter of the courtyard was lined with two rows of Tihama couches, their high wooden frames strung with twine and upholstered with cushions, cloths, and pillows [*farash*] newly covered and pressed in honour of the festivities.

A perch on one of these couches – which stand high so the air circulates underneath them, a necessity in the torrid Zabidi climate – is quite comfortable after one has hoisted oneself up. We selected our seat, eschewing the interior room for the hint of breeze and cooler air in the courtyard.

This first excerpt describes the field: what is Meneley's fieldwork like? What is her field? How is this different from what we have seen thus far?

One guest, Imina, asked to wash her feet before she ascended; she had inadvertently stepped into a large mud puddle on the street. It is the height of bad manners to clamber onto a couch with dirty feet.

Jamaliya brought two extra pillows and tucked them behind us, exhorting us to relax. I had finally learned how to sit properly (right knee raised, left leg tucked under); my unconventional seating posture when first in Zabid troubled hostesses, who could not believe I would be comfortable in any position other than theirs. Propriety is satisfied by draping one's long skirts demurely over one's legs.

Placed at intervals were waterpipes [*mada'as*] for the two types of tobacco, leaf [*humi*] and a sweet paste of tobacco mixed with ash and molasses [*maltut*]. Both types had their devotees, who took turns smoking from the pipe closest to them. A few young women brought their own cigarettes, claiming that the shared hose of the waterpipe was a means of passing infections. Older women dismissed this notion by asserting that sickness was from God [*min Allah*] alone. The health hazard of smoking in general is presented on television and in the high school curriculum. Several young graduates, with the self-righteous tone of non-smokers everywhere, occasionally lectured their elders on the dangers of tobacco. Regardless of one's personal opinion of smoking, however, the provision of tobacco and waterpipes is still recognized as a cornerstone of hospitality.

One feels special and pampered as a guest in a Zabidi home; hostesses are experts at making a guest feel as if her comfort is of pre-eminent concern. We had no sooner sat down than Jamaliya brought us glasses of sweet tea, spiced with cardamom, which we sipped as we chatted and observed the guests coming in. Jamaliya and Nadya – as respected for their generosity as they were known for their immaculate housekeeping – were helped in their hostessing duties by several close neighbours and kinswomen, so no guest would have to wait to have her needs met. These women circulated the courtyard, asking the guests if there was anything they wanted [*tishtī hajja?*]. They handed out cool glasses of cola, and put more tobacco in the waterpipe when someone called out that it was empty. High tables are placed in front of the couches, with large thermos jugs of cool, incensed water, to refresh the chewers from the dehydrating effects of qat. Although daily qat chewing is not as universal among Zabidi women as it is among men, many women describe its mildly stimulating quality as indispensable to relaxation although the focus in women's gatherings is more on qat exchange than consumption.

We began rubbing the dust from the qat leaves with our fingers; Magda immediately cleaned a small bunch for me and wordlessly aimed it at my

mouth. This kind of qat exchange is commonly performed between women who are affectively, socially, and, of course, spatially close. As is common for affluent hostesses, Jamaliya distributed a generous portion of qat to each of the chewing guests. We protested loudly, claiming that we would never possibly consume that much; Jamaliya merely smiled, and after entreating us to relax, moved on to exchange hand kisses with a new arrival. Later we each tried to press upon her a bunch of cleaned qat as she whizzed about on her hostly duties, but she accepted only a token of what we each offered.

The hierarchical relationships among Zabid's twenty to thirty 'great' families [sing. *bayt kabir*, pl. *al-kibar*] and the rest of the people are palpable in social gatherings. Everyone acknowledged that the *kibar* were the most respected Zabidi families, but this acknowledgment was not without ambivalence. One often heard darkly muttered criticisms of them, implying that their haughtiness with others had more to do with their wealth than any moral superiority. Although Nadya's family were not of the *kibar*, they were quite comfortably off, well respected, and widely and well connected to several *kibar* families in Zabid. At Nagla's party the grand entrance of sixteen or seventeen lavishly dressed women, part of the 'clique' [*shilla*] of women from Zabid's elite families, created a stir. They paraded in, dripping with gold, and asked previously seated guests to move so they might all sit together. The nearby guests obliged, although I heard some grumbled commentary from a couple of older women. Hamuda, one of the *shilla*'s most forceful personalities, called out to me that I had yet to visit her in her home, and virtually ordered Magda to bring me the following Friday. No sooner had they settled in, with no small degree of fuss (one woman demanding another cushion, a second insisting she would die of thirst if not immediately given water, another oblivious to all, checking her makeup in a small mirror), than Hamuda crankily complained they did not have enough waterpipes. All of these requests – rather imperiously delivered, to my mind – were fulfilled immediately, without comment or noticeable resentment, by the hostesses or their helpers. For the hosts to display anything but voluntary compliance, of course, would be a flagrant transgression of the norms of hospitality, making the hosts look worse than even the most peremptory guest. But judging from the extensive behind-the-scene and after-the-fact commentary, slights or evidence of snobbery never went unregistered in Zabid.

The party was soon buzzing with conversation and the ground bestrewn with discarded qat stems. Qat exchanges flew so fast that women barely had time to chew. Those sitting far from each other sent bunches – either a

small cleaned bundle wrapped in tissue or several long sprigs – with one of the hostesses. In one exchange, mirrored by dozens of others in this gathering, a messenger delivered the gift of qat to Miriam, naming Magda, her friend, as the donor. Miriam looked up as if completely surprised – although these exchanges are a quintessential part of every gathering – crying to Magda, ‘Oh, you must chew!’ [*Khazzini anti!*]. Some time later a recipient usually attempts to return the qat to the donor. Those sitting close together may have small arguments, pressing each other to accept these small gifts of qat. Although these struggles are usually good humoured, women may be quite annoyed if they are not allowed to make a return. Jamila, one of the clique of elite women, sent Sayyida a large bundle of qat. When Sayyida tried to make a return to her, Jamila at first refused, waving the qat away, until Sayyida exclaimed loudly (and indignantly) ‘Try some of mine!’ [*Khazzini min haqqi*]. Sayyida, herself from a great family, did not want to be lumped together with the others to whom Jamila had grandly offered qat. Jamila had earlier given bunches to clients of their family who regularly received charity from them, like the two old servant [*akhdam*] women who stopped in front of Jamila, kissing her hand several times. She made only a token effort to kiss their hands in return, and wordlessly handed them each a portion of qat, which they accepted in like silence, retreating to the furthest couch, a low one by the door.

At the height of the party there were so many guests that we were sitting cheek to jowl and one woman claimed the couches were sagging from the weight of all the guests. This gifted raconteur told an anecdote about one party so well attended that the couches had actually collapsed. Zabidi women are masters of turning unpleasant or frightening experiences into hilarious anecdotes. She entertained us with her vivid description of the chaos which had ensued after the collapse: the spilled drinks, the hot coals from the incense burner, the tangled limbs, and the shrieks.

That evening there were at least one hundred women and girls present, a not uncommon number for a Fortieth party in a prominent family. I had attended three or four similar ones in the preceding few weeks. Wide attendance is a sign of the host family’s strong community support and viable social ties, and is a matter of pride. The day after a party, one finds the hostesses lollygagging about, exhausted, but pleased if they can say, rolling their eyes and waving their hands for dramatic effect, ‘the house was CRAMMED’ [*bayt milan*]. However full the house had been, however, complaints will still be made about who had *not* attended.

I had been in Zabid for several months at this point, and was known to most of the guests at the party, but one woman stopped in front of me, sur-

prised, as my hair and eye colour betrayed me as an outsider, asking Magda, 'Where is she from?' Magda told her that I was from Canada and that she could talk to me herself in Arabic. After making a crack about Canada Dry Cola, a ubiquitous soft drink that seems to constitute Canada's sole fame in Yemen, she asked me the questions I had come to expect: 'Are you married? (Yes) Do you have children? (No) Are you a Muslim? (No) Why don't you convert?' The last question was always difficult, and I disappointed many by not converting on the spot. Magda defended me from the moral questionability which (in local perception) inheres in *not* being a Muslim, by saying that I wore a chador and went out with them every evening and visited the sick. These activities were held up as evidence that although I was not a Muslim, I was behaving as a proper moral person should, in contrast to the outlandish comportment generally expected of Westerners.

The woman noted as well that I had taken up the Yemeni habits of chewing and smoking the waterpipe and asked if I found Zabid beautiful. I said that Zabid was beautiful in many ways except for the awful weather. She agreed, and added the quip which Zabidi women love (after a summer in Zabid, I loved it too), 'If we go to hell [*nar*] after we die, we'll say, "Oh is this all? This is NOTHING, we're from ZABID!"'

Awatif, the young schoolteacher who had introduced me to our host Nadya, squeezed herself in between Magda and me, after berating me soundly for not having visited her. After exchanging similar recriminations with Sayyida – and somewhat less enthusiastic ones with Magda, of whom she was not particularly fond – she turned to me, launching into a whispered tale about a woman sitting across from us. Awatif had once been engaged to her son, but the engagement had been broken once her family heard the rumour that this young man drank alcohol, a stigma in this upright Muslim community, and a charge which carries connotations of bad character regardless of its empirical veracity. Awatif said they had been too hard on the young man, who had been (she believed) temporarily corrupted by some bad friends. She was disappointed as she was eager to get married. This desire – shameful for a Zabidi woman to admit – was suspected by her friends who teased her mercilessly. I was surprised by this conversation; such an intimate (and potentially controversial) topic is usually discussed only with family, and certainly not at large, formal parties. The reason why this is so was inadvertently demonstrated by Magda, who despite her involvement in her conversation with Sayyida, overheard something in ours which caught her interest. 'Who are you talking about?' she pointedly inquired. Awatif gave a vague reply, then looked away and

clammed up; I ignored Magda's inquisitive look. Awatif whispered that I should visit her the following morning to hear the rest of the tale, and turned to a less controversial topic: the propensity of students in the elementary school to drive her (their teacher) crazy with their inattention.

A staple element of hospitality in every social event is the provision of various scents. Nadya came around with a large bottle of perfume, thoroughly spritzing Sayyida and me. Sayyida protested humorously at Nadya's generous excess, 'enough, there's no need to wash me!' Awatif fended off the encroaching bottle, insisting she only wanted a tiny bit on her hands. The incense [*bukhur*] burner, containing an aromatic (and expensive) mixture of gums, woods, and oils, was passed around; we infused our hair and dresses with its fragrant odour. This kind of incense, which is thought to be enticing to men, is proper only for married women. Awatif unleashed an even more fervent protest at the proffering of this incense; she squawked 'No, no' and waved it away with her hands. This type of protest, which I saw in almost every social gathering, seemed almost a tacit staging of a modesty drama: the hostess never expects the proper unmarried girl to accept the incense, but it is inevitably offered, and inevitably declined with exaggerated indignation. Awatif accepted, however, the incense burner bearing aloewood [*ud*], an aromatic wood used by both men and women. Nadya also dabbed a strongly scented oily perfume on our hands; once again our chaste Awatif declined.

Adjacent to us sat a congregation of married and unmarried teenaged girls, the *banat*, giggling and chattering at an impressive clip, away from the older women in front of whom they are expected to be deferential and silent. The waterpipes, lined up at intervals in front of the couches where the older women sit, are not necessary here; in elite and respectable circles, the girls do not smoke or chew qat. They are given tea and cola to drink, and gum and watermelon seeds to munch on; the husks quickly carpet the ground as the qat leaves do in the women's area. No one complained about this implicit segregation; some of the less charitable older women found the indefatigable good spirits of the girls fatuous, while the younger women were not sorry to have their hilarity unchecked.

Awatif and I watched Adila, a beautiful young woman, exquisitely groomed in the latest Zabidi fashion, enter in the wake of her hefty mother-in-law whose girth was matched only by her well-deserved reputation for gossiping and griping. From a tiny Tihama village, Adila was still very much an outsider in Zabid. Her family were rural landowners rather than sharecroppers on Zabidi estates, but all rural people, from the Zabidi perspective, are considered somewhat bumpkinish. Zabidis tend to be eth-

nocentrically unapologetic for their urban snobbery, convinced of the rightness and elegance of their own etiquette and manners. In addition to this stigma, Adila's husband had a dreadful reputation, as did his female relatives, who were avoided as much as possible. They were notorious for their sharp tongues in Zabid, where gossiping was by no means unknown, but universally feared and condemned. Even their relatives did not like them, and this was suspect in a community where kinship ties are one of the most important means of affiliation.

Adila's husband was alleged to have mistreated his first wife, whom he divorced after she had born him five children. This wife had been very popular in our neighbourhood, and although she now lived in her father's house some distance away, she was invariably greeted like a long-lost sister when she visited her old neighbours. Although Adila's beauty was often admired – and with the Zabidi inclination for invidious distinction compared favourably to that of the first wife – no one seemed to like her. Adila had been in Zabid for nearly two years but had yet to make any good friends, unusual in a place as gregarious as Zabid. She always mentioned the invitations she had received from notable Zabidi families, and never complained of the fact that no one returned her visits, or accepted her as a friend. While they were still invited out, very few people would enter their house at all; her immediate attachment to me, another outsider, suggested a desperate loneliness.

Adila had quickly adopted Zabidi fashion in dress, showing taste [*dhawq*] in her selection of gowns, but her mastery of Zabidi fashion was in contrast to her *gaucherie* in the field of Zabidi manners, which remained unmistakably 'other.' She greeted women she hardly knew with several kisses on one cheek which denotes a warm and affectionate closeness. This feigned intimacy made the younger girls collapse into giggles, as did her lavish distribution of candies and gum from her purse. (This is the province of the hostess, and Adila's actions had a peculiar infelicity.) She chattered feverishly in a high-pitched voice about clothes and then provoked another fit of giggles when she began to praise elaborately Awatif's eyebrows. (Zabidis *do* admire thick eyebrows, and Awatif's were fine, but there was something jarring in Adila's framing of this compliment which was evident even to a novice like myself.) Awatif barely choked back a snort of laughter and abruptly rose, claiming she really ought to see if the hostesses needed any help.

This party, like every one, had two definable sessions, named after the afternoon and evening prayers [*asr* and *layl*]. At sundown [*maghrib*] many women change venues, to make another call or go home to pray. Magda

and I were showing our loyalty to Nadya by staying for the entire duration of the party. Therefore, Magda asked if she could perform her *maghrib* prayers there rather than traipsing back to her own house. Nadya took her into another courtyard with an adjoining room and washing facilities for her pre-prayer ablutions and provided her with a clean cotton headcloth and a prayer mat. After a small exodus at *maghrib*, when many of the girls went home to study for their next day at school, an even greater influx of guests arrived, primarily older women, for the later session of the party.

One of the incoming guests was Zohara, whose quick wit and easy smile made her a pleasure to be around. Before she could say a word, I declared I was angry with her because she had forgotten all about me. She laughed at my imitation of the Zabidi greeting style and teasingly faulted *me* for never visiting *her*, only other people. She introduced me to her two friends, from a well-known family from another quarter of Zabid; they invited me to visit them at their house the following week.

We spent the rest of the evening pleasantly chatting; Zohara, admiring her friend's new frock, special for the evening, leaned over and felt the fabric, asking 'how much?' [*bikam?*]. When the sum was proudly reported, Zohara pronounced 'Oh, that's nothing!' [*bilash!*], which carries the connotation of 'what a good deal' if the quality is good, and if it is not, merely 'cheap' in its derogatory sense. When Zohara's two friends rose to leave around 9:00 p.m., choruses of protests were heard from Zohara and the hostesses. Nadya demanded to know where they were going, and insisted they sit a little longer. Zohara chided them, 'You don't have children or husbands to go to!', referring implicitly to the obligations of married women which have to be balanced with visiting duties. Unmarried women who were beyond marriageable age (usually twenty-five to thirty) were often the social mainstays of their families, visiting widely and providing the organizing force behind social events in their own homes. Zohara's friends made their escape by putting on their chadors while countering the pressure from their hostesses with a description of the length of the walk home ahead of them.

I received a bundle of qat from 'Umara, the wife of Mahmud Hazimi, whom we had called on earlier. Even she and her friends, a group of older women from prestigious households in our neighbourhood, diehard socialites who loved to loiter late passing judgment on neighbourhood affairs, were showing signs of wear at 9:45 p.m. Magda, whose health was not strong, looked completely exhausted, and I was always wiped out by the heat. We were joined by Magda's sister, who had spent the evening chatting with her friends, but was now ready for the refuge of their own house. We

gained our release from the warm remonstrations of our hostesses by insisting we were the first ones to arrive – not entirely true, but close enough to pass – only to confront Sowsan, who loudly berated us for leaving early, although it is rare for any guest to stay past 10:00 p.m. Sowsan was a *muzayyina*, a forceful woman, who did not appear to be the slightest bit intimidated by the higher-status women at the party. She made a good living from her services at weddings, which included inviting guests and preparing the bride for the wedding festivities. Higher-status people would sometimes complain bitterly behind her back about her high fees, but no one seemed eager to criticize the fearless Sowsan to her face; she had no qualms about making a scene in public. Nor was she bound as fully by the modesty code. As Magda and I made our way for the door, Sowsan asked me loudly if my husband liked Zabidi incense, a query which is often used to tease young brides about sex and the pregnancy everyone anticipates will be announced shortly after the marriage. I merely smiled, and she called out that they were expecting me to have a Zabidi baby. She then insisted I give her greetings to my husband. Although laughing, several women urged her to stop – sending greetings to an unrelated man is highly improper – and a chorus of ‘Shame, shame’ [*ayb*, ‘*ayb*] went up. I was happy enough when Magda sensed my discomfort and hustled me out of the courtyard and into the streets. Even she was laughing, however, and asked me if I was embarrassed [*mustahiya*] by the talk, saying that Sowsan just didn’t ‘know’ shame. She also tried to pump me for the details of my conversation with Awatif, but I prevaricated. Magda knew I was lying, but she did not push further. I had only started to receive information about more intimate and controversial topics as the result of my strict policy of discretion, one which was necessary in a place like Zabid where the fear of having one’s private business trotted around town is reason enough not to talk to a stranger. I kept to this policy even with Magda, my dearest friend, who was occasionally irked that I kept things from her, but ultimately reassured, I think, that I would not spread her family’s secrets around.

In my field notes for this evening, I had noted how much I had enjoyed the party, how much, for me, it seemed to capture what Zabidis extol in *khuruj*: the sense of a women’s community united by a common etiquette, the communal enactment of the values of hospitality and the gracious receipt of it, and the cooperation of guests with hosts in putting on a show of finery. But I had been at parties where I had not been as comfortable with the hosts or the other guests, or had observed controversy between hosts and guests or between guests. And that evening too, there were many possible experiences to be had: Zabid is not the only place in which one

person's social pinnacle is another's nadir, after all. A few guests looked bored, some, like Adila, obviously discomfited, others, like Magda, were vexed by unpleasant encounters. Status differences were marked or contested, and this event, like every social encounter, was charged with both positive and negative aspects and sentiments.

We were quiet on the way home, Magda complaining of exhaustion and me of the heat. Magda and her sister walked me to my door on the way to their house, asking if my husband was home; if he had not been, I would have been invited back to their house so I would not have to sit alone. Given the enthusiasm with which going out is touted, it is surprising to witness the relief that women display on arriving home. On several occasions when I had stopped at Magda's house on my way home, I noticed they tore off their chadors, sighing as they flopped down on the nearest couch, appealing to a sister, mother, aunt, or daughter to bring them a glass of tea, while sharing the news of the party with those who had remained at home. The excitement which characterized the departure is traded for exhaustion and the relief on reaching one's home. This sentiment, I suspect, is related to the fact that every social encounter is more than relaxation; there are always elements of confrontation, of conflict and competition. Each interaction is characterized by a sense of being in the public eye and an intense awareness of the fact that one's comportment – and others' treatment of oneself – are evaluated and could potentially have consequence for familial reputation. Small incidents taking place in these gatherings – snubs, kindnesses, compliments, criticisms, and insults – may or may not have immediately tangible repercussions for a family's status, but are always taken seriously. The sense that one is safest and most secure from the vantage point of one's own *bayt* is evident when women return to their own houses after these formal outings. Although families are not without their strife and internal criticism, they are bound by a fierce loyalty which inclines them to protect each other from the critical commentary of others. In this respect, one's own *bayt* is a refuge from the competition and evaluation of public life.

nor one's family's place in society can ever be taken for granted. C. Eickelman (1984, 1988) explicitly addresses the role women play in the politics of the Omani community she studied, particularly by trying to effect the social mobility of their families.

Creating their families' honour and prestige is part of women's work in Zabid. When I arrived in Zabid it was immediately obvious that visiting involved more than enjoyment, although countless times I was told that the beauty and pleasure of Zabid lay in the custom of going out; certainly the gracious manners of Zabidi women, their witty conversation, and cool and comfortable reception rooms made visiting in Zabid more enjoyable than one would have thought possible given the wretched climate. But beyond the pleasurable aspect of this practice, which unites all Zabidi women, is the undercurrent of divisive competition. Whether as hostesses or guests, women are representatives of their families in public and face the often-critical evaluation of their peers. Women create or maintain ties between families through visiting, but they also create distinctions. The intensity with which women pursue visits is related to the constant competition between families in Zabid. The practice of women's visiting is fraught with the same tensions and contradictions which underlie Zabidi society as a whole: the elements at odds are dependence and independence, equality and hierarchy, solidarity and distinction, and enjoyment and danger.

Gender and Social Life

Social life is segregated by gender: this is the premise underlying sociability beyond the family in Zabid, and visiting as a social practice. Women's visiting is strictly separated from men's visiting; no male past puberty is allowed into a women's visit, unless he is a servant [*khadim*]. To this extent, women do make up a separate community (cf. Abu-Lughod 1985). Although the separation of men's and women's social lives requires continuous effort, the idea that the two must never coincide is an unquestioned part of the common-sense assumptions of everyday life.

The interior of a man's home is off-limits to all other non-related men. In his discussion of how an interior space is formed and transformed in a Lebanese community, Gilsenan writes:

Women will never appear there (the *maglis*) when any kind of public event is going on. It is not that a woman's presence pollutes the room. It is rather the nature of the occasion that determines her presence or absence. As soon as the *maglis* reverts to

'private' use, then it is part of the 'inside' again and thus belongs to her realm, too. In this space, where inside and outside meet, where nonfamily enters into the one setting in the house into which they may enter without violation or profaning of the basic sacredness of family space, the women remain within the closed and nonvisible space to which no stranger may penetrate. (1982:183)

Only from a male perspective can the interior of others' homes appear closed, non-visible, or private. In Zabid, at certain times of the day, these interior spaces are open to receive the peers of women, whether friends or strangers. Women and children move freely between houses during the mornings and late afternoons and evenings; doors are never locked and female visitors simply appear in the courtyard. Male visitors must either yell for the man outside his door or commandeer a child to announce their presence. In Zabid it is a man who must defer to the female guests in his home. When a man returns home in the evening, he always pauses before entering the interior of his house and calls out '*Fi nas?*' [Are there any people here?]. He cannot enter until all the guests have left.

Although women's social life beyond the family takes place exclusively in the company of women, in each other's homes, it is in no sense perceived of as a private sphere opposed to a public sphere which is the domain of men.⁶ On the basis of her work in an Omani village, C. Eickelman suggests that the private sphere is the circle of family members, while the public one is where family members encounter non-related others (1984, 1988). This formulation is similar to the divisions in Zabidi society itself; when male and female family members interact with each other in the home, the home then becomes a private sphere relative to both male and female (adult) outsiders. Members of a particular *bayt* share not only the moral space of the house and a budget, but a common reputation as well. All members, male or female, are obliged to uphold the reputation of their *bayt* through their appropriate comportment in public. It is not that the women's social life comprises a private sphere; rather, it is a public sphere that is separate from the public which men face.⁷ Unless women are specifically talking about

6 Aswad makes a similar point in her study of visiting between women of elite Arab landowning families in Turkey, reminding us that because visiting takes place within homes, it should not be confused with a domestic activity as opposed to a public one (1978:480). The validity of equating the oppositions of public/private: men/women: political/domestic has also been criticized by Nelson (1974), Rogers (1975), and Joseph (1983).

7 Men's and women's public spheres never coincide for sociable occasions. Non-related men and women do come into contact in the schools and hospitals, but these interactions are strictly defined as work.

men or Zabid in general, when they speak of going out with the *nas*, they are referring only to female people.⁸

Meeker notes that honour [*sharaf*] requires a wider community which recognizes honourable behaviour (1976:250). One meets the community, the *nas*, in the course of going out. *Khuruj* is a competitive practice in that one's family's place in the community – their honour – must continually be recognized by regular visits from those with whom one has connections. These connections that Zabidi families have with other families can be seen, as Bourdieu suggests for the Kabyle of Algeria, as an intrinsic part of a family's patrimony (1977:178). Both female and male family members are responsible, in their separate public spheres, for the maintenance of this valued patrimony, a practice which is the stuff of daily politicking in Zabid. The social connections can be considered part of the family's resource base which, although not necessarily in a direct or incontrovertible way, open up options. In a society where access to resources is, to a great extent, accorded through personal connections, keeping these connections viable is tantamount to keeping open avenues of opportunity.⁹

Varieties of Visits

Any event – joyful, tragic, or mundane – is marked by visiting. In this sense, the practice of women's visiting resembles a Maussian system of 'total prestations,' a society in which the obligation to pay, to receive, and to reciprocate visits is mandatory (Mauss 1970:3, 10–11). The etiquette pertaining to performance of visits is strict; visits are, as Bourdieu notes, formalities which are considered so natural that 'abstention amounts to a refusal or a challenge' (1977:95). There are several occasions when all the women with whom a family has social connections must visit or risk jeopardizing the relationship. Mandatory visits are owed on the occasion of life-cycle events (birth, marriage, and death), religious festivals, and in times of illness.

When a woman gives birth, all her friends, neighbours, and those who have connections to her natal family or her husband's family will visit the new mother at least once.¹⁰ Married women who have given birth bring

8 I confessed to a Zabidi friend that when my husband and I were living in San'a' we had both chewed qat with men. She asked me, puzzled, if I had not known any 'people' in San'a'.

9 See Lancaster (1981) for an illustration of this process in an Arabian tribal society.

10 This practice is widespread in the Gulf region. Saudi women now regularly give birth in hospital; the new mother's family members bring the essentials of hospitality there to host visitors (Yamani 1987).

with their neighbours and certainly did not seem to make the rounds of social calls to which Zabidi women are accustomed. My neighbours had never been out of Zabid before, and for the first time their assumptions about their own patterns of sociability, and about how one ought to behave when out in public, were thrown into relief.

This chapter explores this Zabidi style of sociability and its strict and explicit rules, which govern appropriate comportment in public interactions between women. The etiquette of hospitality, the exchanges which take place within visits, and the grooming and adornment practices appropriate for public interactions are described.

Hostesses and Guests

A guest's physical presence in the hostess's home serves to create the worth and identity of the hostess and her family. A hostess is honoured by the presence of her guests but must make her guests feel welcome, desired, and comfortable, to ensure that they will continue to visit her. The hostess's insistent hospitality, implicitly at least, recognizes her dependence on her guests. The hostess clearly honours her guest by graciously extending her hospitality, and, to a great extent, a guest can expect this as her right. This etiquette of interaction mediates tensions between equality and hierarchy, and identity and distinction, facilitating the process of the reproduction (or alteration) of relationships.

A primary principle of visiting is that guests in one's own home must always be given precedence over obligations to others in the community; if guests arrive, it would be churlish to admit to previous plans to go out. Zabidi women are very skilled in making one feel as if they, the hostesses, had been doing nothing but hoping for one's visit. *Kibar* families, whose connections are wide-ranging, can expect guests at any time. Ideally, homes are kept in a state of readiness to receive guests: clean and stocked with the essentials of hospitality. It is very unusual to find a house with the door locked; in most cases, at least one teenaged girl or adult woman is present to receive guests and supervise the youngest children.¹

Just as the reception room should be neat and clean, so should the guests. Washing and donning fresh clothing is a prerequisite for attending

1 In 'Amran, according to Dorsky, women leave their babies locked in rooms and go out to visit (1986:81). I never heard of such a practice in Zabid. In poor families with only one adult woman, men return home around 7:00 p.m. to watch the children while their wives go out.

any afternoon gathering. It is considered crass to go out without washing or changing from work clothes into the fancier clothes appropriate for visiting.² Further, personal cleanliness is not only an important element of comportment of properly socialized adults; it is an aspect of moral behaviour toward others. Zabidi women rub alum [*shabb*] a deodorizing substance, under their arms before they go out because, they say, 'How can one relax if one is disturbed by a bad smell?' Zabidis are very sensitive to odours and certainly do not want a reputation for smelling bad. Cleanliness is connected to religious morality, as the hadith of the Prophet Muhammad frequently mention that the considerate person is the clean person (Kanafani 1983:93).³ Filthy guests not only leave themselves open to criticism, but insult the hostess as well. Both men and women are very fastidious about their clothing when they appear in public. Garments are always freshly ironed and spotless, at least among the higher-status families.⁴

One of the most apparent aspects of the etiquette of hospitality is the aggressive welcoming that the hostess gives her guests. A hostess urges her guests to come in, and when they make a move to leave, she entreats them to stay longer. The hostess also tries to extract her guest's recent social engagements to discern if her family has been neglected for another. When the guest is finally able to extricate herself, the hostess orders her to return again soon.⁵ As Bourdieu (1977:180) notes, giving or 'squandering' time is a gift, one which is certainly necessary to social life in Zabid. This importance of giving time to the hostess is evident in her

- 2 Occasionally a woman returning from a late errand would drop in to see her neighbours but she would adamantly refuse to take off her chador, on the grounds that she would be embarrassed [*mustahiya*] because she had not washed or changed. Clean, but not fancy clothes, are worn on informal visits in the morning.
- 3 Zabid is similar in this respect to the United Arab Emirates as described by Kanafani: 'Smelly or ugly guests in dirty surroundings would inspire repulsion and aloofness and prevent the enjoyment of conversation and hospitality' (1983:2).
- 4 Women are proud to have pristinely turned-out family members, although keeping them that way in Zabid's heat and dust requires considerable labour.
- 5 The visitor is bade to come in [*Idkhuli!*], and then asked 'Why haven't we seen you for so long?' This question is ubiquitous; it may be asked even of people one has seen a few days earlier. A guest is instructed to sit 'up' [*Itla'!*] on the high Tihama couches, is urged to settle herself comfortably, and is offered additional pillows. When the guest makes a move to leave, the hostess will demand, 'Where to?' [*Fayn?*]. She will argue that the guest has only just arrived, even if she has been present for two hours. The hostess will insist that the guest stay for just a while longer [*Ijlisi qalil!*] or urge her to put off a visit to another home. As the hostess sees the guest to the door, she will exhort her to come again soon [*'Ajili, 'ajili!*].

reproofs to a guest for having been absent, in her reluctance to let the guest leave, and in her insistence on a return visit. Being willing to spend the time to visit someone's house, to relax and enjoy oneself by accepting hospitality, is necessary for the maintenance of the relationship. A hostess will feel slighted if the guest sits only for a token period, hurriedly drinks a cup of tea, and departs in a rush.

The hostess is responsible for the comfort of her guests; she provides tea, incensed water, the waterpipe [*mada'a*] for those who smoke tobacco, and often a 'Canada,' a Canada Dry cola. The hostess urges her guests to relax [*fasha'i*].⁶ Women who chew qat bring small bundles of it with them, but the hostess, if she is of a *bayt kabir*, will usually present her guests with an additional ample portion of qat. Toasted watermelon seeds and chewing gum are provided for those who do not chew qat. Cooked food is never served at this time, as it is said to be impossible to relax with food odours around.⁷ Qat chewing and eating are, of course, mutually exclusive. Scents are an integral part of hospitality: they are thought to enhance relaxation. Guests are offered two types of incense, for the hair and clothes, and liberally doused with two types of perfume, a scented oil and a spray.⁸

It is understood that the hostess and her hospitality will be evaluated by her public, her guests. The often-expressed fear of people's talk is not unfounded. Indeed, one of the ways status is constituted is by talk. Guests create the status of the hostess through praising her, not to her face, but to others. Positive evaluations include reports that the party was 'heavenly' [*jinan*] or that 'the house was packed' [*bayt milan*].⁹ However,

6 This word is most often used as an imperative and also as an interrogative – *Fasha'ti?* (Did you relax, enjoy yourself?) *Fasha'i* was described to me as a distinctively Zabidi word; my consultant impishly told me that the reason is that the only place one could truly relax is Zabid. It is interchangeable with *istaribi* or *irtabi*. I suspect the origin of the word is from the root *fasha*, which means 'to make the rounds or circulate'; it is always used in the context of going out. In one respect at least, relaxation is going out.

7 Zabidi women claim to be sickened by the habits of the Yemeni women who live in Saudi Arabia (where qat is forbidden), because they leave trays of food around as they visit. Meals in Zabid are dispatched quickly and without much conversation. Hands are washed thoroughly afterward, and perfumed, as lingering food smells are thought unpleasant when exchanging hand kisses.

8 Along with *khuruj*, Zabid is said to be made beautiful by its luxurious scents [*rihas*]. Almost every elite family seems to have a special recipe for mixed perfume oils and incenses.

9 Caton describes how at weddings in tribal areas of Yemen, the guest makes a formalized 'return' to the host by praising him with poetry (1990:28).

if the house is dirty, a guest feels justified in describing, in graphic terms, the horrors which confronted her. It is clear, however, that the motivation to offer hospitality does not stem merely from fear of negative public evaluation, although that is certainly an explicitly recognized element. Women take pride and satisfaction in offering hospitality generously and ensuring the comfort of their guests. A gracious older woman explained to me that although she had never in her life smoked the *mada'a*, she would treat the hoses of the pipe with cardamom and perfume to make them pleasant for the guests who did. Kanafani, discussing hospitality in the Emirates, states: 'To honor a guest is a duty (wajib) of the hostess: if a woman honors her guest she honors herself and if she does not, she demeans herself' (1983:101). There is a similar understanding of hospitality in Zabid. Wikan also notes that in Sohar, Oman, honour is created through being gracious to others, 'The person's own honour, in the sense of value both in own and others' eyes, in fact requires that she or he honours others' (1984:641).

The solicitous insistence of the hostess is in contrast with the stylized, decorous refusal of the guest to show any need or desire for the hospitality of the host. When women accept tea, they often do not drink all of it; they say this is because of honour [*namus*].¹⁰ Women are reluctant to appear as if they are in desperate need of the refreshment offered, or as if they are greedy and vulgar. When a woman is given a cola or a glass of water, she will drink only half, passing the rest to the guest seated beside her. I was told that a display of *namus* is only necessary if one is out in public; with family or close friends, one drinks as much as one desires. Guests often protest mightily when the hostess gives them qat or perfume; they try to accept only a token amount. This calculated reluctance expresses the fact that the guest is delicate, restrained, and in control of her physical appetites.

On the other hand, it is not impolite for guests to request something or even to order the hostess to perform a service.¹¹ I never saw a hostess express resentment at these initiatives from a guest; rather, putting a finger under one eye and then the other, she would commonly say, '*Min*

¹⁰ *Namus* is honour or code. I never heard Zabidi women use *namus* to refer to the sexual honour of women which has to be protected by the men (as discussed by Meeker 1976 and Dresch 1989). In Zabid it refers to self-respect derived from appropriate comportment in the sense of conforming to etiquette.

¹¹ The most petulant requests usually came from the nicotine-addicted, urging the hostess to add fresh tobacco. Non-smokers were rather disdainful of this obviously expressed physical dependence.

'*nyuni*' (literally, 'From my eyes,' a phrase which expresses sincerity). It is not considered necessary to say thank you [*shukran*] for hospitality. (I was thought odd for always thanking people when they handed me something. The hostess frequently murmured in response to my thank you 'no thanks are necessary for a duty' [*La shukr 'ala wajib*].) The guests never immediately recompense their hostess; a hostess today will be a guest tomorrow who can expect the same hospitality in return.¹²

The guest and the hostess are mutually dependent on each other: the guest is allowing herself to be temporarily encompassed by the host family, and the hostess is concerned to ensure that the guest will continue to honour her with her presence. The etiquette of visiting reflects not only the centrality of visits to constitution of honourable status in Zabid but also its centrality to moral personhood. By honouring others through conforming to this etiquette, one creates oneself as a moral person. Transgressions harm oneself more than others.¹³

Greetings

In Zabid, as elsewhere in Yemen and the Middle East, proper salutation is closely governed by etiquette. Greeting signifies at least a minimal recognition of the social personhood of the other, which most individuals can expect as their right; it provides a base line for interaction (Caton 1986:296). While greeting is far too ordinary to be performed with sombre reverence, it does have a quality of moral compulsion about it.¹⁴ Before taking a seat at a social gathering, a woman must greet those present. Greeting often subtly encodes closeness and not-so-subtly encodes hierarchical

- 12 This style of receiving hospitality from a hostess reminded me of how Zabidi women receive presents. When I brought a friend a present from the capital, she said, in a rather aggressive tone, 'Why did you bother yourself?' The gift was quickly tucked away, without thanks or even inspection. Later she described her delight, not to me, but to another woman within my hearing. Betteridge describes a similar mode of gift receipt in Iran (1985).
- 13 Veblen wittily remarks that adherence to etiquette is a feature of the 'worthy human soul' (1979:48). This connection of etiquette and personhood is also made by Elias (1978), and by Beidelman (1986:60) who notes that etiquette 'lies at the heart of how people imagine themselves as cultured beings.' Beeman (1986) discusses Iranian etiquette in terms of ideas of the person and the nature of the social order.
- 14 'When greeting a person one is in a very real sense engaging in a religious act, calling on God to bestow his favor on the addressee' (Caton 1986:294).

Preface

Skim this section, paying attention only to Meneley's description of her fieldwork.

If you are interested, her photos (mostly taken by her husband) are also included.

The research on which this book is based was carried out in the town of Zabid in the Republic of Yemen in 1989–90. It was made possible by grants from the Social Sciences and Humanities Council of Canada and the American Institute for Yemeni Studies. Permission to conduct research was granted by Dr 'Abd al-Aziz al-Maqalih, director of the Yemen Center for Research and Studies. I am grateful for the aid of Taha al-Qirbi and Dr Abu Baqr al-Qirbi. Ibrahim Sharafuddin, Dr 'Abd al-Malik al-Maqrani of San'a' University, Duncan MacInnes and Donna Ives, and the directors of the American Institute for Yemeni Studies, Jeff Meissner and Scott Ralston, made time spent in the capital enjoyable. Ed Keall of the Royal Ontario Museum gave me advice before I left for Yemen. I thank Drs Steve Cummings and Muhammad Al-Khader for aid and kindness when I was ill.

The wit and friendship of my colleagues in graduate school and beyond – Allyson Purpura, Vilma Santiago, Lindsay DuBois, Noha Sadek, and Susan Kovacs – brightened long days of writing.

My professors at New York University, Tom Beidelman, Fred Myers, and Bambi Schieffelin, offered critical advice with kindness and wit. The expertise of Dale Eickelman and Lila Abu-Lughod in Middle Eastern anthropology has guided and inspired me. I also appreciate the encouragement of Janice Boddy and Michael Lambek of the University of Toronto. The readers for the University of Toronto Press had many excellent suggestions for the revision of my original manuscript. I appreciate the care Virgil Duff, the executive editor at the University of Toronto Press, and my editor, Diane Mew, took of my manuscript during the publishing process.

For their confidence in me and their many years of material and emotional support, I thank my family, especially my parents, Robert and Rose

Meneley. I cannot envision any of it happening without them. Thanks are also due to Nijole and Algimantas Banelis, my parents-in-law, for their interest in this project and their care.

My husband, Vaidila Banelis, took a leave of absence from his architectural firm to accompany me to Yemen. He had the good sense to view the experience as an opportunity rather than an onerous duty, and the grace not to blame me for hardships endured on my behalf. I know he found his own rewards not only in the wonderful Yemeni architecture, but also in his friendships in Zabid. I thank him for his care when I was sick, and his insights into men's lives in Zabid. He took most of the photographs in this book.

We arrived in Zabid, an ancient town on Yemen's coastal plain, in June 1989, just in time for the sweltering summer. We presented our official papers from the Yemen Center for Research and Studies to the governor of Zabid. Our official documents stated that I was the researcher and that my husband, an architect, was my 'escort' [*murafiq*]. This interpretation of our relationship was the respectable one in Yemen. It is unusual for women to travel without a male guardian, and in this way, the presence of my husband was made understandable.

Within a few days we had found a charming, if tired, house to rent. The once-wealthy owners had fallen on hard times, and the section of their house we were to rent was long past its prime. Its comfort and charm revived a bit after the bats and pigeons had been evicted and our landlords arranged for the windows to be fixed. We also installed a new front door – complete with doorbell – and fixed the wooden partition between the two sections of the house. In this way, we ensured a certain degree of privacy and established ourselves as a 'family' distinct from that of our landlords. I am grateful for the aid of my landlady. Without even feigning the faintest interest in my research, she nonetheless furthered my understanding of Zabidi society a great deal with her explicit lectures on comportment. In time I welcomed her designation of herself as my 'mother in Yemen' who would watch over me while I was far from my mother in Canada. Although I insisted on an independence that was hardly daughterly, we became very close.

We were welcomed in Zabid with a warmth and generosity notable even in Yemen, a country known for hospitality, despite some ambivalence about non-Muslims from the 'decadent' Western world. Our arrival in Zabid coincided with the beginning of the wedding season and before we had finished arranging our house, both my husband and I were swamped with invitations to weddings – my husband to the men's events and I to the

women's. In Zabid, weddings are the most important cultural events. Zabidis consider an invitation to a wedding reception the perfect way of introducing a foreigner to the style of Zabidi hospitality of which they are immensely proud. Huge tentlike structures are erected; wooden frames are covered in cotton fabric, and are decorated to convey an air of opulence. The interior walls and ceilings of the tents are covered with brightly coloured carpets. Bunches of bananas and ornaments covered in jasmine flowers are hung from the ceilings. At my first wedding reception, I found couches arranged like bleachers to allow all of the guests – at least a thousand – a view of the raised dais. Here the bride sat in all her finery, surrounded by dozens of wildly excited little girls, who were vying with each other for a chance to dance to the music which was blaring from speakers. The guests were hardly less splendid than the bride, bedecked with gold jewelry and brilliantly coloured gowns. Jasmine flowers set off their hair, and their hands and feet were adorned with henna and *khidhab* (a temporary black tatoo in a lacy design.) I found the sheer scale of such events as astounding and impressive as my Zabidi hosts had hoped I would, and this gathering was only one in a series of week-long parties celebrating this particular wedding, and this wedding itself was only one of the dozens of similar weddings held that summer.

The necessity of recognizing others in the community by accepting invitations to their homes or wedding parties was immediately obvious. I expected women's visiting to be important as it is so often mentioned in ethnographic and travel literature about the Arabian Peninsula. However, I was not prepared for the emotional intensity that accompanied the organization of these visits. Women's social life in Zabid is a hectic one of perpetual motion, and obligations to others are forever being weighed, juggled, fulfilled, or neglected. The process of recognition draws on terms like 'anger' [*za'al*], 'love' [*hubb*], and 'shame' [*ayb*] and is subject to continual negotiation.

Learning about one's expected social obligations was not mysterious. Zabidi women are not at all reluctant to express what they think of one's behaviour and try to direct it in what they consider appropriate ways. The constant questioning of another's activities is an accepted convention employed in the service of interpreting and often altering the actions of others. In my first few months in Zabid I witnessed countless discussions of who had not shown up at so-and-so's wedding, of a person who had neglected one family for another, of an invitation improperly delivered or neglected entirely, and I was questioned often about my whereabouts. Immediately after I related where I had been the evening before, the inter-

rogating woman frequently would respond with a snort and say, 'Why did you visit *her* instead of *me*?' This intense questioning was not limited to me; indeed, such interrogations are so commonplace as to be practically greetings in themselves. I soon imitated the rest of the women, who answer such queries evasively in hopes of avoiding angry accusations of neglect.

The whirl of the wedding season quieted somewhat with the beginning of the school year in the fall, although daily visits and formal invited parties continued. Keeping up with my social calls was time-consuming, but it was essential to my research. Zabidi women proudly demand respect in the form of proper greetings and visits: without these proprieties, a relationship does not exist, even for the purpose of 'research.' Not only is visiting competitive but, on another level, sociable engagement with others is an essential element of moral personhood. My research would not have advanced without the acceptance granted to me because I behaved like a 'proper' person. Indeed, for the most part people were uninterested in whether I did research or not. My relationships were constituted as friendships rather than as ones of researcher and informant.

It is largely through the training I received in how to fulfil properly obligations to friends, neighbours, and acquaintances that my understanding of Zabidi society is derived. People who come to live in Zabid, I was told, must 'become citified' [*utamaddanu*], a process which is said to be accomplished when strangers begin to participate in social life in the appropriate Zabidi fashion. From a Zabidi perspective, the term connotes sophistication and refinement of manners. The confidence with which they uphold the rightness and superiority of Zabidi social life is immensely 'persuasive' both to Zabidis and to outsiders who move there.

As in many Middle Eastern, Muslim societies, social life in Zabid is governed by strict gender segregation. The Zabidis approved of our conformity to this local norm: my husband avoided the company of women, as did I the company of men. Like Zabidis, we socialized solely with our respective genders. Zabidi women often expressed relief that I was not scantily dressed – as were the European tourists, who periodically paraded through the Zabidi market, the *suq* – but still my dress was open to criticism. Despite the fact that I was careful to cover my body from ankle and wrist to neck, and to wear a scarf covering my hair, the Zabidi women declared my garb inadequate and began to press me to adopt a chador,¹ a

1 I use the conventional spelling of this word of Iranian origin. The Zabidi pronunciation could be transliterated as *shaydar*. In the capital, the same garb is referred to by a word of Turkish origin, *sharshaf*.

long black robe worn over a dress in public places. I resisted at first, feeling uncomfortable with the notion of wearing a chador, but I soon became just as uncomfortable as the only adult woman not wearing one.

By adopting a chador, I solved the other problem Zabidi women had with my clothes, which were modest enough to be worn on the street, but inappropriate for any of the several kinds of festive events. For such occasions, I adopted the gauzy cotton print dress which many Zabidi women wear with a brassiere and a cotton underskirt while attending formal social functions. This dress is considered fancy enough for special occasions but cannot possibly be worn on the street because the cloth is virtually transparent.

I soon became more socially adept under the tireless tutelage of my friends, who were proud of my small accomplishments in the field of Zabidi manners and fashions. They constantly urged me to take the step necessary to becoming a proper social being in Zabid – to convert to Islam. They settled for training me in the proper comportment of a Muslim woman. Many confided before we left that they were sure I would come around soon. Women would tuck strands of my hair into my scarf and lavishly compliment me both for wearing a chador and for avoiding the company of men, as any decent and sane Yemeni Muslim woman would.

Donning a chador had important implications for my research. I gained universal approbation from the women, and several men spoke approvingly to my husband of my appropriate comportment. But once I began behaving as a 'proper' woman, men behaved toward me as 'proper' men should, by avoiding conversations with me beyond brief (and abruptly phrased) inquiries about my husband. As a result, I did not conduct any first-hand research on male views of family, sociability, or religion. All of my time was spent with the women; it was they who taught me and it is primarily their perspective which informs this work.

Although my husband does not claim anthropological expertise, he widened my perspective with his insight into men's social life, which was gained by a participation as constant as my own was with the women. The information I obtained about the men's world was derived in the same way that Zabidi women's knowledge is: through male relatives or husbands, and through other women's commentary on their male kin and affines. I do not present a separate section on men's activities, but the information contributed by my husband or my female friends about male practices is noted throughout the text in footnotes and anecdotes.

My understanding of the nature of Zabidi society came by way of participation in both everyday and remarkable events: I attended special events such as weddings, funerals, and religious celebrations. I participated daily

in formal calls in the afternoon and informal calls in the morning. At first I avoided exclusive association with any one family or circle and was invited to many large, formal parties. In this way, I gained a sense of the importance of women's sociability for the social standing of their families in the Zabidi community.

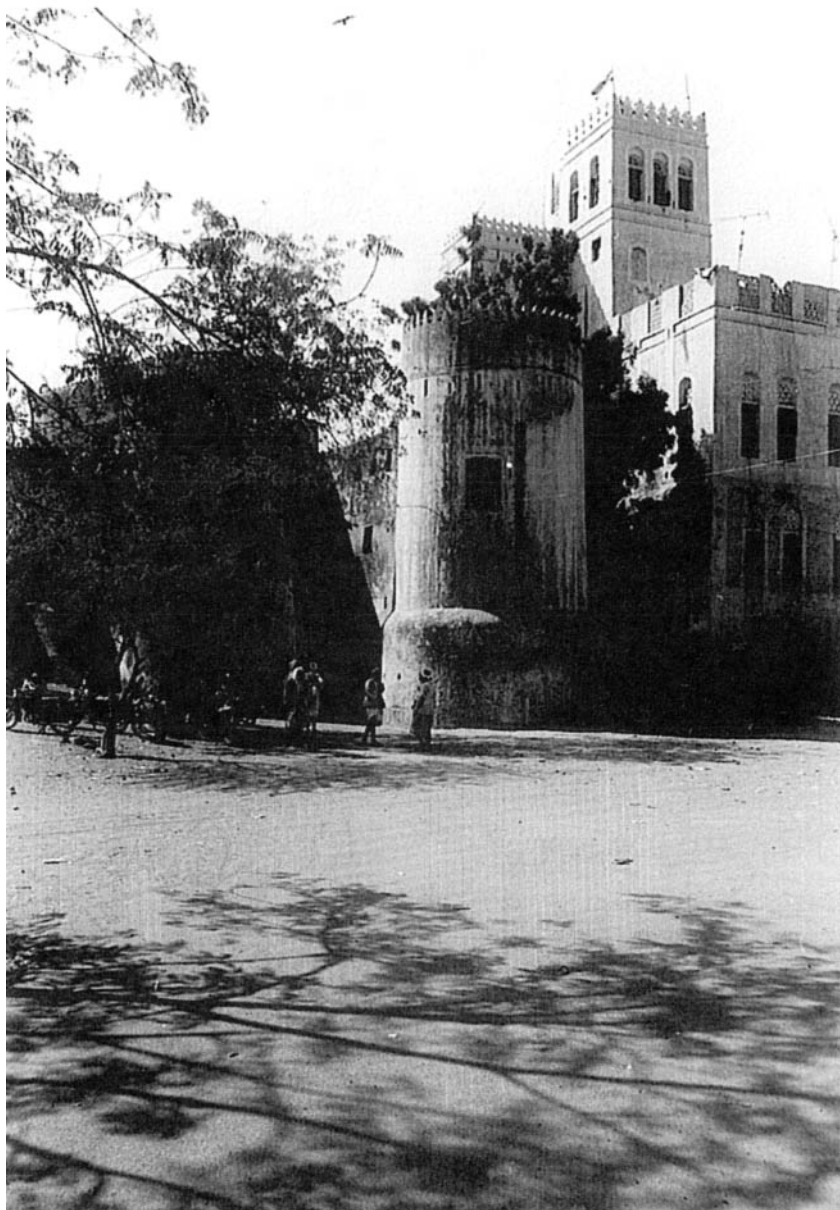
During the second half of my fieldwork I focused as much as possible on informal interviews with women with whom I had developed strong and trusting relationships. My account of Zabidi society owes much to their help and insight. During informal visits in the morning I was able to discuss with them, in relative privacy, various topics: modesty; practices such as female circumcision; the competition for prestige between families; religious practices; and the position of women in families, as wives, mothers, sisters and daughters.

It was difficult in some ways to live in Zabid – coping with the oppressive heat was always a struggle – but it was also very hard to leave. I am particularly indebted to my dearest friend who helped me more than anyone else with her insights into Zabidi society. Her friendship was a source of great comfort to me in the field, and my happiest moments were spent with her. The news of her death after I left the field has caused me much pain. If there is anything of value here, it is because of her. My joy at finishing this work is shadowed by sadness at the knowledge that I cannot again have the pleasure of her company.

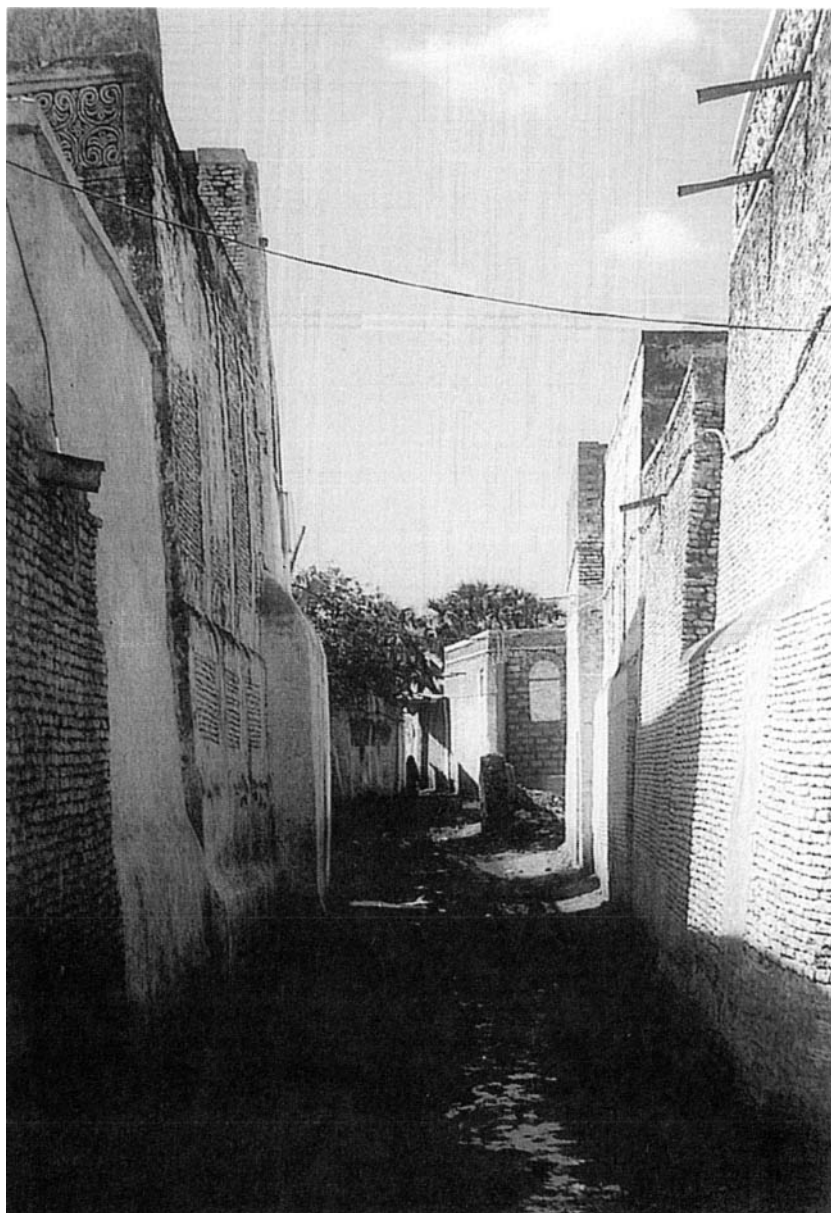
The Zabidi women specifically requested that no family names be used in this work, which deals with aspects of life not usually recorded in historical documents. Therefore all the personal and family names are pseudonyms. However, in order to retain ethnographic significance, the relevant facts about the status of the person or family in the Zabidi community are undisguised. Those interested in the notable Zabidi families whose histories (of male members) are recorded in biographical dictionaries and historical documents can therefore gain from this work a general sense of the contemporary lives of female members of these families. There are no photographs of those with whom I worked, as this would be an infringement of their standards of modesty. Instead there are pictures of their male relatives and children, of the men's counterparts of women's social events, and the houses they inhabit.



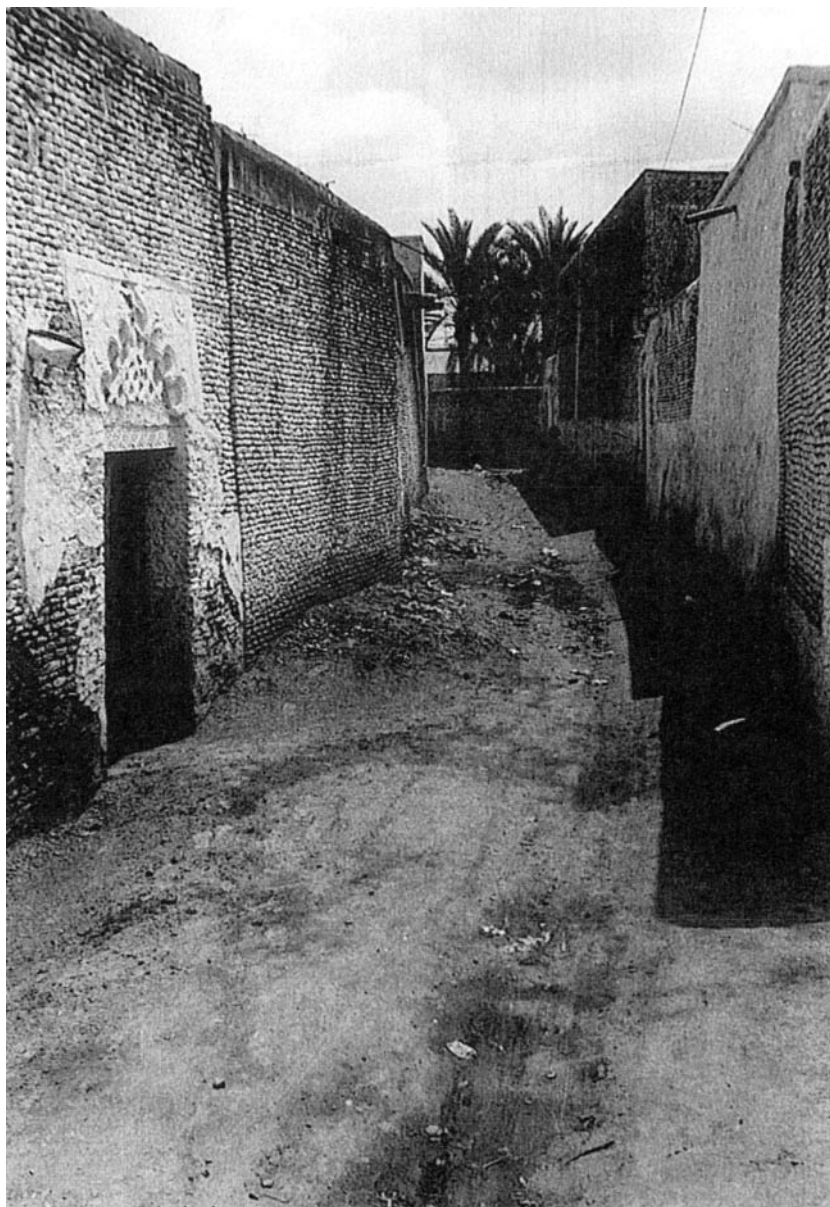
Rooftop view of Zabid



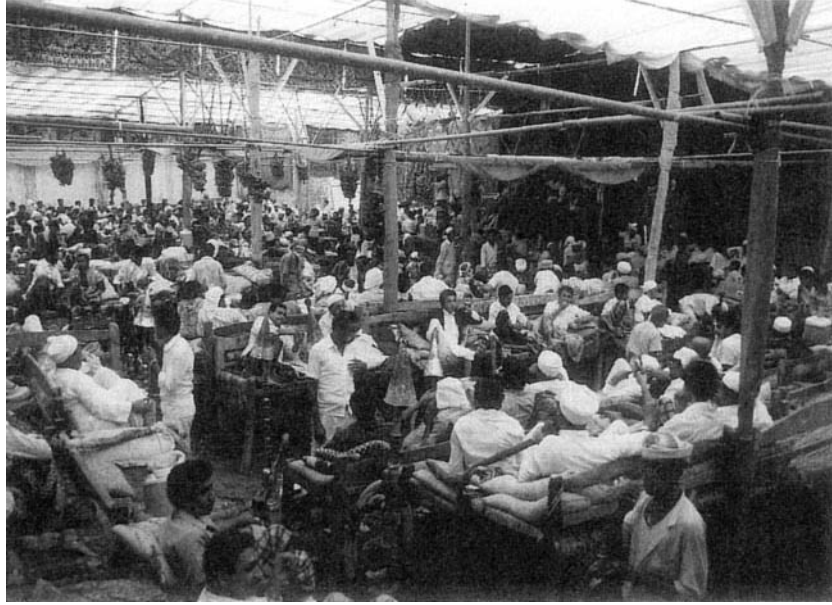
Zabid's main square [*maydan*], with government building

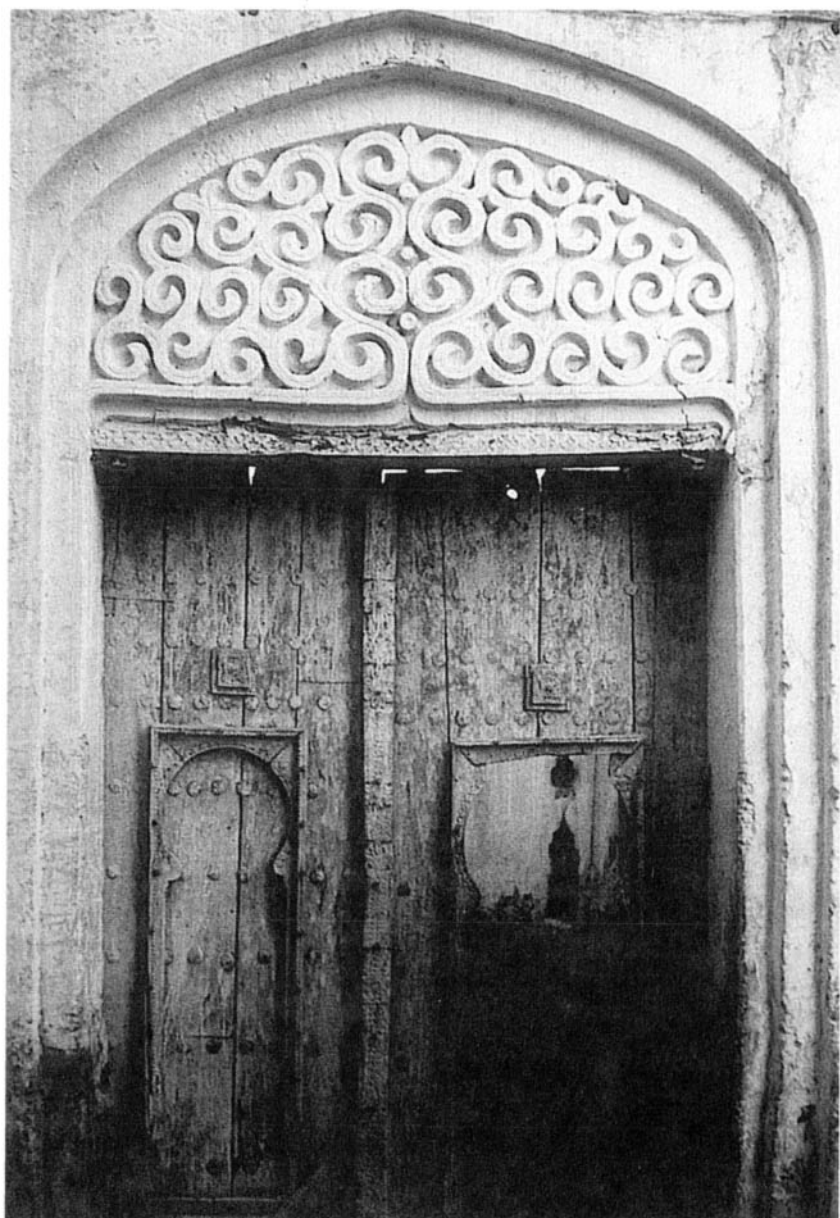


Street scene with electrical wires

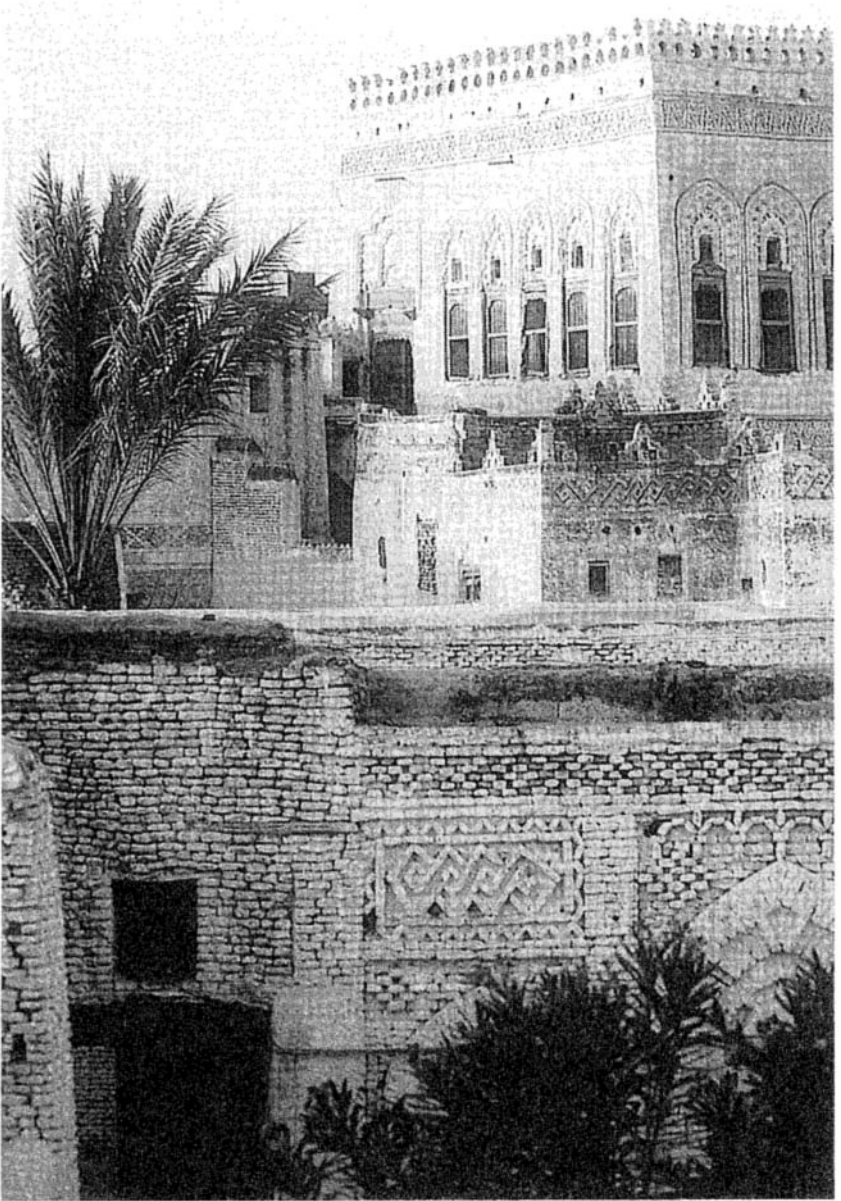


Street scene showing Zabid's high walls and obscure entrances





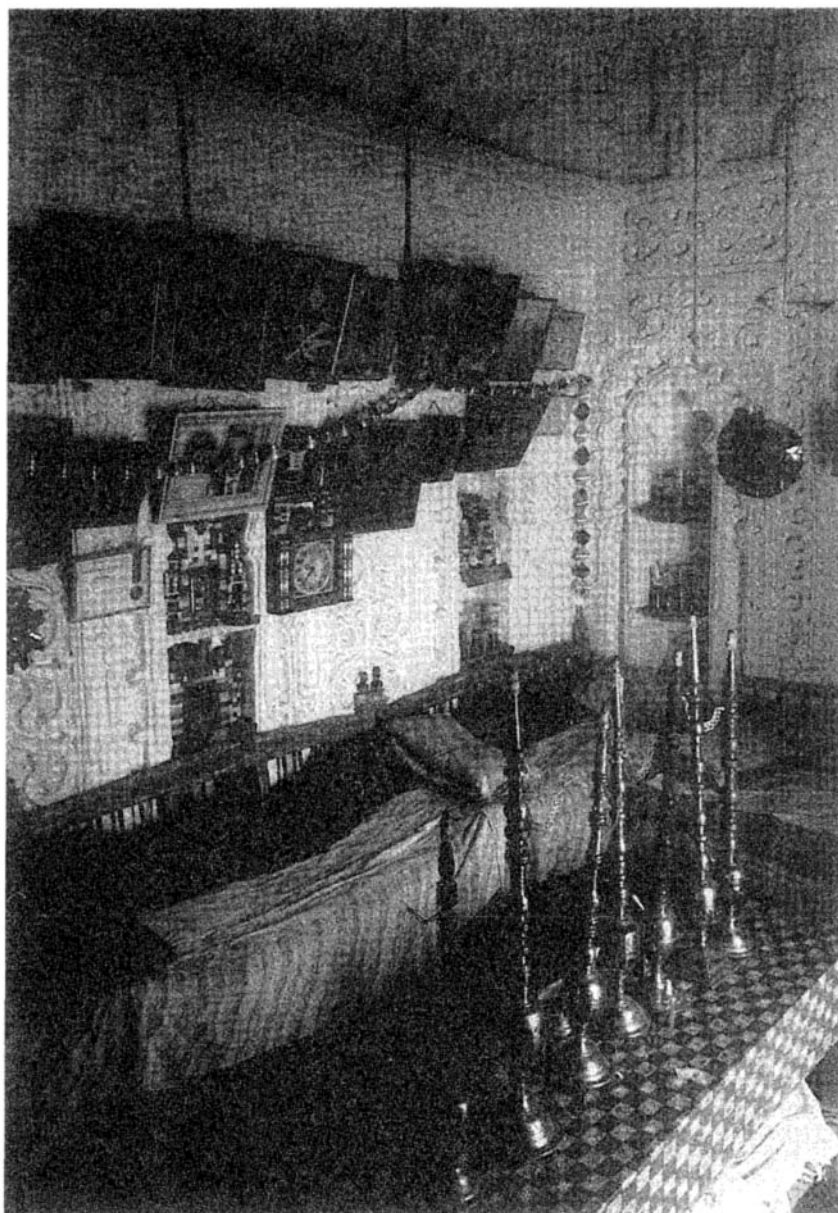
Door to a Zabidi house



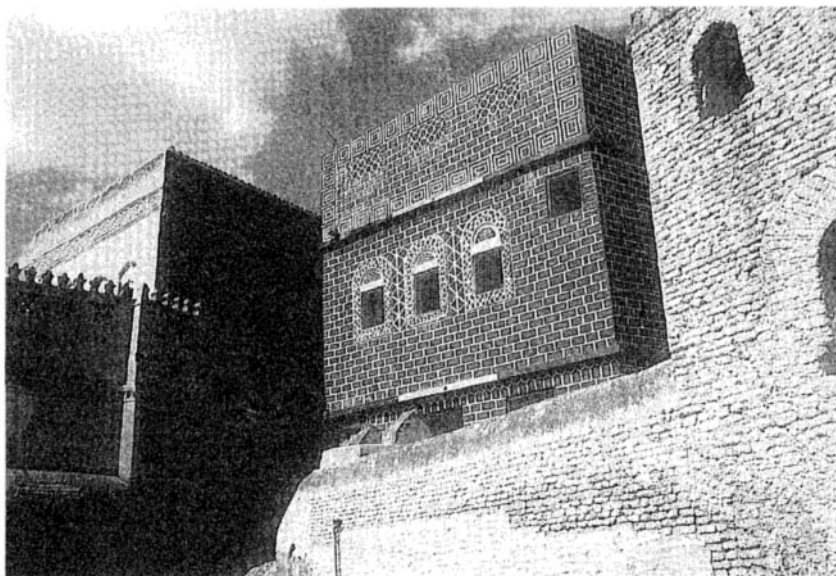
Exterior view of houses



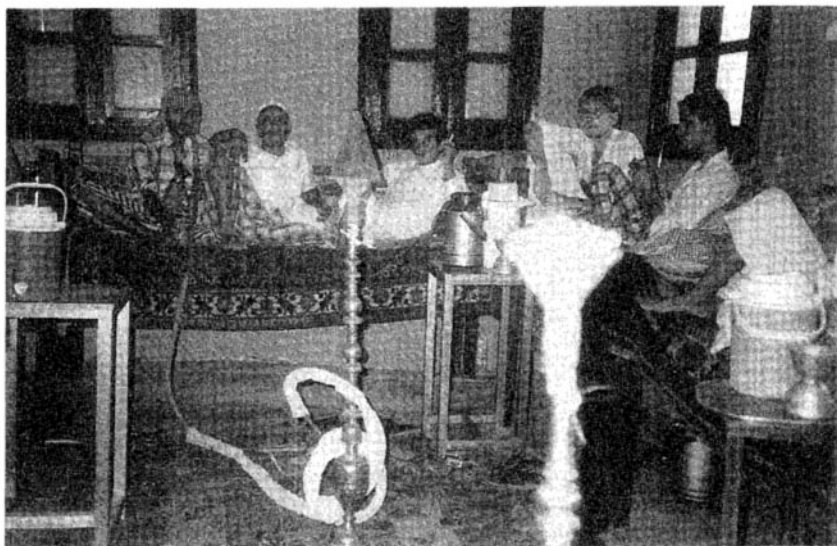
View of courtyard and exterior facade



Interior room



Modern house addition



Qat chew in men's *mabraz*



Children dressed for a 'grown-up' party



Children on an informal visit



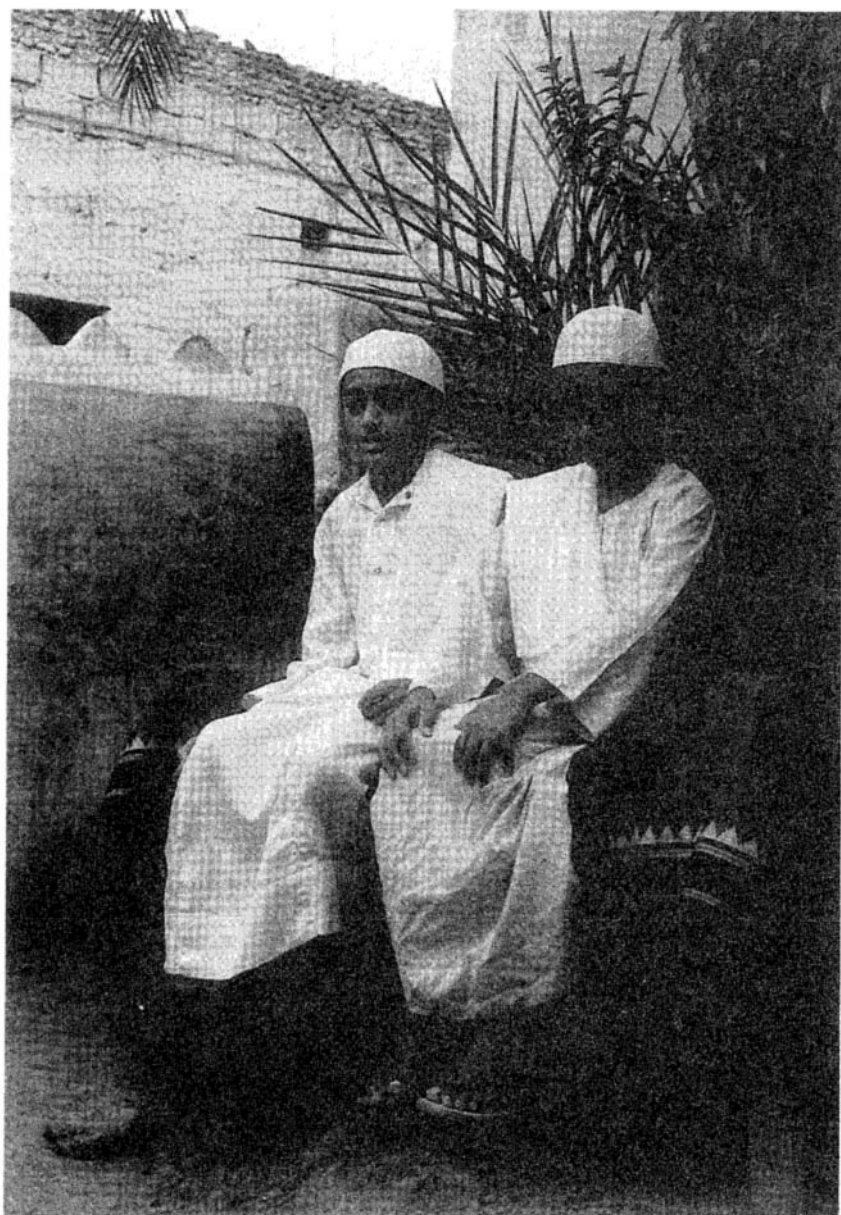
Grooms at a wedding



Wedding lunch



Zabidi mosque



Children dressed for the mosque



Men's *khatim*